

INT. MANUELA -- LOS ANGELES

Adapted verbatim from the canonical source transcript (291 turns).

SPEAKER 1

Oh my gosh, okay, I'm gonna ready recording. We have to do consent for California to party. Benjamin de Kosnik, it's de ninth. We're at Manuela in LA. I consent to that.

SPEAKER 2

I consent. I can do this recording. I consent, all right. And I love my friends who were in the show.

SPEAKER 3

Yeah. We love your friends who are in the show, yeah, the fault lies. They didn't write it, yeah.

SPEAKER 4

But like I said before, Filipino performers deserve so much better. They deserve a lot more.

SPEAKER 1

Okay, why was there a drag queen in that show?

SPEAKER 3

Compare character a la cabaret,

SPEAKER 2

the impetus that I had heard. So you you saw it on Broadway? Or No? No, we

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

saw it here at Mark Taper.

SPEAKER 2

Okay, so there's nothing to compare to, yeah. So the did you see it on

Broadway? No, okay, I've just heard all about, yeah, a lot of it, yeah, not all about. So originally, that character is a deejay, okay, who just is on stage the whole time deejaying the show and as the announcer The MC. So they added that as a drag queen. So they changed it. They added the IL depict character, no, but they were always a drag queen, right? No, it was a deejay.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah. Never a drag queen, yeah.

SPEAKER 4

Just male, and they were just, like, in the booth, right? Yeah, he

SPEAKER 2

just did it on a microphone. Didn't go out into the ground, didn't okay. So that was something new that the director wanted as a well, because he's homosexual, yeah, and be, I think he, he wanted,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

you mean, the directory, the directory, yeah,

SPEAKER 2

and he wanted that character, allegedly, to be more active, okay, versus having to stay at the Dee Jay, staging, right? He's like, and we're not gonna have live deejaying, since this person just gonna fake like, I don't, I don't want to fake the deejay part. I guess, okay,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

and I guess just the commentary of

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

how drag

SPEAKER 2

this drag character can parody somebody with love at the beginning, but then kind of reject, kind of reject it, yeah, yeah. Later storyline when you take it all off and you're like, when she said, You used to love me, yeah? Where that love he wanted it to be like that love was so apparent in the beginning, and then you strip it away, because you can learn to not love someone, yeah, even after you idolize them at the beginning.

SPEAKER 3

So it is about Imelda, Phantom, that character, yeah. And then

SPEAKER 2

again, he did. They did what they could with the script. And you there's no way around it that this musical is glorifying,

SPEAKER 4

yeah, even though they keep saying so much that it's not, it's 100

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

that's the conceit.

SPEAKER 2

Yeah, yeah, we would think like 90, 90% of it, right? Yeah, it was like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

and it's, it takes such a sad it

SPEAKER 3

takes such a sad turn when it starts to be about Ninoy, Kena, like, right? Then a really bad song

enters,

SPEAKER 2

and we just barely meet him in the beginning. Yeah, it's a little bit right?

SPEAKER 3

We don't really know. And then it's about this broken love story right between

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Ninoy and thank you

SPEAKER 3

and then. And then it's just sad costume. It's all sad, sad funeral, sad colors, bad music.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

She was like, the shoes they

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah, I didn't want

SPEAKER 1

to say she said, Justine and Sean are like the shoes, the shoes, the

SPEAKER 3

shoes and those from literally beige, chunky heel, like beige chunky like the most boring pumps ever like Payless pumps, yeah, two, like bedazzled or flats, slingback flats, which Imelda would never wear those, I mean, and never wear the Payless pumps either, but maybe when she was poor. But then there was the one scene with a cocaine in New York, with the glitter ball and the cocaine and the fake fosse choreography, which I hated, because I'm like, fosse plus Imelda, no, right, right, but like

in that one cocaine scene, she had real shoes on, like, real heels that were sold on. And I was like, Where are where are these shoes for the rest of this play?

SPEAKER 1

And I'm just gonna impose a note of historical fact here is that Abigail and I wanted to bring them separate, just because of the mint perfect. I was like, I don't want them to touch it. We have been to Tacloban, and we have seen the Imelda Museum in Tacloban, which includes

SPEAKER 3

at her, yeah, she built this house like she has this whole compound where she stole, where she stored all her looted art, and I'm sure someone was purchased, including money, yeah, and

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

all her shoes, some of the

SPEAKER 3

shoes, yeah, some. I mean, nobody has all the shoes, yeah, yeah. I mean, right. So we feel like, like, you know, not with so much research into Imelda, but just seeing imelda's castle on in taco Ben, and also watching the Ramona de is documentary, which we have not watched. Yeah, the hero lives love is such a big miss. Like, it doesn't even honor the super crazy that really is an elder. Like she's so much crazier than that she is not. I mean, aside from the Disney princessification of her, which is way, not her? Yeah, it's also like, you don't even know this woman. She is way she is on she's outside of the solar system. Yeah? She her concepts of reality are so batshit bonkers, crazy town banana pants.

Like she is a very entertaining person, yeah, but not in this way that's like, supposed to be relatable, where, like, she's like, of course, I hate Ferdinand Marcos, he betrayed me. Like, what? And like,

SPEAKER 4

that moment of like, I was cheated on, let me go, like, oppress a bunch of people right now.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah. What am I? What am I supposed to do about the way?

SPEAKER 1

When we know that historically accurate thing for Filipino women in the Philippines to do is to get a dance instructor, right,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

or a phone instructor, so anything,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

any kind of interior

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

designer, hot man, yeah, yeah,

SPEAKER 3

dresser, yeah. I mean it also is like, I think it's really clear from Imelda is whatever, from the way Imelda tells the story, even though she doesn't tell it this way, you can you just know that Imelda picked him and built his career, that she was like, I am going to get to the top through this, man, yeah, and I'm gonna do everything it takes to kind of stage and dramaturg this performance. And then, you know the title of the play, Here Lies Love.

Is what she put on his headstone. It's his gravestone. And she tells this romantic tale of how, this is my great love lost, and so that's why I put on his headstone. Here Lies Love. There is my love. So it's like it defeats imelda's own performance of the great love story, historically, you know, please. But like anyway, that's imelda's Here Lies Love. But the play Here Lies Love doesn't even allude to her narrative of this incredible lifelong romance, or something.

SPEAKER 4

How much do you know about, like, the conception

SPEAKER 3

of this music? Oh, yeah, nothing. But I feel like a lot can be inferred. But I would

SPEAKER 1

love to, before we get to that, can I just say one other note directly from Makati, the supermodels, and Makati, it's EMA Marcos, and they use the words fag hag directly. I mean, okay, so she is that's Aimee is well known for this, so I feel like there's a confusion about the sister and mother, the daughter and the mother in this depiction about what's what. Anyway, sorry to interrupt. Please go ahead.

SPEAKER 4

Yeah. So what's his name? The guy that was just on the that we just watched that horrible number on Stephen Colbert, it's his name. Whoever? The guy that wrote

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

David Burke, yes.

SPEAKER 4

So he just didn't know who she was, but found this picture of her in a club, and was like, this woman looks fabulous. And then did, like, mild research, which I don't understand how you miss in any research about her, right?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

But the whole thing, yeah, yeah.

SPEAKER 4

But like, did just, like some outreach, oh, she was fabulous. Let this fabulous musical, right? And then wrote it. Brought, brought in fat boy, slim to write it. They wrote it, yeah. And then they brought the bin. They brought in a Filipino consultant, who, I think was Alex's mom, who was like, Do you know this was a dictator? And they're like, no, oh, so

SPEAKER 3

do we know that Alex's mom worked on this play?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

That's why she was one of the producers.

SPEAKER 3

That's our stage not a stage manager, but our stage directions reader. We called her the assistant director. Her mom is a famous on Philippine de. Her mom is a famous Filipino, American producer. Got it, okay?

SPEAKER 2

Yeah. So on opening night, a statement was

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

read on opening night. On brought from,

SPEAKER 2

no, here, oh, here I went to opening night. Oh, and she was Alex's mom was in the Philippines, and she's like, we have, we have a statement from the executive producer, or whatever her title was, from G she's currently in the Philippines, but celebrating her dad's birthday, but she wanted to read this, and it was essentially like, welcome. We the reason that we did this play was because there are the LA is the biggest Filipino diaspora in the nation. And we hope that this piece is a conversation starter. It is at no means meant to glorify the happenings, but it's a conversation starter. Wow, of how we got there. And I hope you enjoy and continue talking about this show. It was like they're apologizing for the show. She was like, apologizing for the show before it even,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

because she knew the context in LA,

SPEAKER 2

like, you're not gonna like this, but think of it as like, well, this is how we talk about it. Yeah. So that's where the problem lies. It's like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Here lies the problem.

SPEAKER 4

And like in the whole thing is like in, like, Les Miserables, they don't even mention the people that are being oppressed, right? Let alone them giving, yeah, the

oppressors aren't even mentioned, like, let alone getting music numbers, let the main character the whole story, right, right? You know, like, I don't want to see how, like Louis the whatever, had a horrible childhood.

SPEAKER 1

Yeah, you know, well, Abigail was talking about Sophia Coppola's depiction of Marie Antoinette as a possible analog, where it was all like soft lens, and what cakes can I eat, and what dresses am I wearing? And about, like, the scene and not about, yeah, you're gonna get your head shot. Yeah, yeah,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

I guess I do leave.

SPEAKER 3

I mean, I don't. I also don't believe in glorifying Marie Antoinette. But, like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

feel as

SPEAKER 3

there's something about dear life's love that really asks the audience to be a fan of Imelda Marcos for quite a lot of the play, yeah. And also the audience loved it and ate it all up.

SPEAKER 2

So what was interesting, yeah, can I say, well, being there on opening night versus being there on a later date?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah, we went to closing when?

SPEAKER 2

Yeah, when? So it was like a lot of Filipino people in the opening the audience, yeah, when? That moment where the drag version introduced Imelda, there were audible like, booze, oh, and no cheers, oh, in opening night, yeah. And the drag queen was like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

yes, playing that up.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

We saw it. We booed and like, people like, looked at us, yeah, yeah. And we're like, Oh, you don't know,

SPEAKER 3

and like so for almost all, I mean, for the whole play, I never applauded Imelda or Marcos or the bad government, but I applaud for, like Pinoy Kino songs and like the revolution songs, even though they were the worst songs and clearly written after the fact. But like, I everybody else loved all those songs, and it was tons of Filipinos in the audience. Like, people were coming with, like, you know, like, like eight people from their family, yeah? Or, like, their three best girlfriends, or whatever. Like, there were all kinds of selfies being done beforehand. And then everybody, like, moves in together. Merch was being sold, yeah. And then, like, everybody's like, yay. The whole time, like, hooray, yay. Good, good number. I like the dancing, like everybody in the whole theater was and then it ended, and then everybody gave standing ovations. And the only time there was any sentiment of, like, a political, like a political sentiment in the audience was at the very, very end, the last thing

projected is that Imelda son is now present in the Philippines. And then people were like, oh, like, was like a surprise, yeah.

SPEAKER 2

It was like, definitely behind me. The first time I saw it. She that last, that last projection, yeah, she goes the fuck yeah.

SPEAKER 3

Blackout, so, I mean, partly, this is about, you know, like, I have a there was somebody who is a close, like one of the my closest students, when I was a grad student and she was an undergrad, was a Filipina American in at Northwestern, and she now lives in happily Bay, and she and I have talked, over the years many times about her fandom for Imelda. And like, the last time we talked about this, which was, like, recently, I was like, Kat, you got to drop the Imelda fan. Yeah. Like, it's not okay. And especially now you can see the Trump gilded Ivanka Melania thing. You have to see how bad it is to be a fan of Imelda. And she said, Well, you know, growing up, there just wasn't any other Filipino person to be a fan of, and Imelda is like this glamorous whole hand. And I really think many Filipino and Filipino American people only relate to Filipino culture and history in these very surface ways, right? Where it's like, not real history. It's just like, well, this person's famous and this person's famous and this person's famous, and one of them is a fucking dictator, but that they're all just celebrities, yeah, you know, because I was

SPEAKER 4

so confused that, why like, like, in the musical, The Wedding Singer,

there always has to be a Filipino woman in the cast, because there's a character that's an Imelda, like impersonation. And I'm like, why the hell is this character? Yeah, then that also means that you can't cast the Philips, like, if you have no more than one Filipino person, that's the only part they can. That's interesting, which drives me crazy. Yeah, it's like, well, or

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah, but you're saying in the 80s,

SPEAKER 2

she her status. That's why wedding singers, like a wedding singer, wasn't

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

made in the 80s. It was only about that.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

I got a muscles over here. Yes. Mustard, polenta,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

thank you. That does like the best version.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

I wanted this more than chili. Chilies. Anyway, yeah,

SPEAKER 1

yeah, the actual theater people here a question, yeah. There was a very high percentage of the time in here lies love with music, exactly, yeah, and it wasn't a really musical as much as it was a soundtrack, and the

SPEAKER 4

story was told through like them,
telling you what happened on
projection, yeah, and then he went
to America,

SPEAKER 1

that was more like libretto, that a
libretto would be projected like
that, but Not playing more like a

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

silent film, inner title, right?

SPEAKER 2

Because, like, each are not in the
script, yeah, like this production
specific choice to do that, right,

SPEAKER 3

right, right? I mean, it's clear
this production really has tried to
rescue this point. They tried. It
is really clear, could they not?
Could they have found or written a
better song than mama. When I grow
up, I want to be a drummer, oh
yeah, oh yeah. I mean, really, but,

SPEAKER 4

and I personally didn't like a
singer song in the show, a couple
of not get stuck in my head, but
not because I like them, because my
head, my brain is like, making fun
of how bad.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Oh, I like it, yeah.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

You remember that they put this on
stage, yeah?

SPEAKER 3

And also, like, I mean, to have no
Corey, and I know Cory is a gesture

too, but like to really, it's like, to me, the obvious move would have been to, this is a character, turn it into a Korean Kino musical, if you really want to rescue it. Yeah. But even after Nino dies, it's like, then they take away that, that actresses yellow dress, and put her in that horrible, boring uniform and that colorless, like concentration camp uniform, and then, you know, just have the outside.

SPEAKER 2

And those are, like, they were so proud of this custom, you know, right?

SPEAKER 1

I mean, they were pretty cool, I thought, I mean, the actual fashion I was liking,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

sandwich, yes,

SPEAKER 5

it's not peas, no mint. We saw the chicken.

SPEAKER 4

Yeah, looks pretty good. Is it possible to order one more of these?

SPEAKER 3

Yeah, absolutely. Can I get a spoon? Yeah, of course. Where were your seats? I know, but that, I think that is for sharing maybe, you know,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

oh, that's my little I think that's for me to deal with

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

these things. You're too American

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

for that. Well, I don't need a sandwich. Not that

SPEAKER 3

I don't, yes, I don't care how American, Filipino Americans are. But I think the spoon or not spoon is a key indicator. Oh, Shawna is generally good enough my sister, when she became a McKinsey consultant after college, you know, like, didn't order spoons. Like, didn't ask for spoons at fancy restaurants and clients. And so she was just trying to eat with a fork. And so then she realized she was pushing food into her fork with her hand, and she had to stop trying to, like, make the spoon, make the fork into the spoon.

SPEAKER 4

Wow, I'm really and I'm learning more about the eating with the spoon, because that gets so much more of a sauce content, which, for me is the most important part of the

SPEAKER 3

food is just the vehicle for sauce, right, right, right. Indeed, indo people, Indonesians, always give you a spoon. They have a spoon thing too. Oh, they do, yeah. I feel like whenever Polynesian thing was in that part of the world, everybody decided on the spoon. I mean, first your hands. If you can use your hands, that's the first choice. But then if you need to

SPEAKER 1

use other things, use food. Did

people get up and dance in the middle? Because part of this thing, Abigail is very leery. She was like, if we're expected to do audience interaction dance, because

SPEAKER 3

New York, thank you so much. Like that, yeah, the Broadway version, you were standing the whole time, I think, right, yes,

SPEAKER 2

if you didn't, if you didn't have the seats in the in the balcony,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

the only other seat was

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

on the floor, and that was like a dance pit,

SPEAKER 2

and it was like an open concept stage with platforms that moved on and off and around.

SPEAKER 4

Imagine standing in a club situation while that funeral is happening, right?

SPEAKER 3

But they didn't have that that I bet in the Broadway version, I bet the Broadway version didn't have any of the Ninoy

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Aquino stuff.

SPEAKER 4

It did because that song, drummer song, the drummer song was what

SPEAKER 2

so the that was the friend that
played Imelda in this one. She
originated that way. Well, sort of
the

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

mother she, like half, originated

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

it with, with

SPEAKER 3

Lea Salonga. Oh, Lea Salonga played
it sometimes they gave Leo Salonga
that dumb song, yeah, oh yeah, oh
yeah. My God, that really makes me
sad. Where were your seats now, we
were stage left. We were pretty far
over. No, we were like, closer to
the center.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

But yeah, because Okay, so

SPEAKER 1

just we didn't get any glitter, so
we were far, okay, but just outside
the glitter red drop, we were

SPEAKER 4

so one thing I love a thrust like,
that's my favorite kind of theater.
And this was the worst staging I
have ever seen in a dress. Like,
the entire time she was downstage
center, all the way far, and so we
just got her back. Oh, and then I

SPEAKER 3

also thought the set was awful.
Okay, okay, so never really, yeah,
no, no, it's only my fucking scenic
design instructor at Berkeley made
those sets, and he brought in my

enemy student. Well, he's the one enemy former student did was the dramaturge, because Arnell brought him in so, like, I know, right? It's like, so boring.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

And also because, like, have you seen show in that theater before? No, oh, sure.

SPEAKER 4

So there's a stage back there that was, like, blocked off. It's not just up in the center. They just decided to just use that thrust part and, like, block off pretty much the whole stage. And then, like, those, like, like, weird bleacher things that, like, moved were curved inward,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

so all that. But I felt like that

SPEAKER 1

was just before a visual effect, because they wanted it to be a semi circle that opened, I understand the

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

geometric, sculptural parts of that, but as a stage

SPEAKER 4

so, like, when, when, like, Imelda would go sit in the middle, and they would sit behind her, if you were on the side, you got no one, not a single you got backs. Oh, no. Like, and the thing about a thrust is, is you got back, yeah? And the thing that's weird, and the thing about thrust is, like, usually you will get a back or two, yeah. And the goal is that everyone has one person that's important, right? And

so maybe you're getting one
person's back in the conversation,
and you're seeing one person's
friend. So it's always a little
different, no matter where you sit,
right? We didn't get really good.
He didn't get anything for us.
Like, nothing, nothing was ever
like, I was sent it, yeah. I was
like, I don't even know if my
friend is wearing makeup right

SPEAKER 2

now, right like, Oh my gosh. When I
had to, I had to hold my tongue so
hard when I principally Dean beef
and Alex. Was like, I love the
music. The set is amazing.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

When I got closer, that's like,
Sean didn't notice,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

I think partially because
everything was just painted gray.
But like,

SPEAKER 4

those, so great. Those like columns
that had the disco balls inside,
yeah, the Filipino, like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

woven that, like,

SPEAKER 2

pattern that's on, like, the
peacock chairs, yeah, yeah.

SPEAKER 4

But, like, it was only because it
was that close to us that I see
that right? And, like, once you get
like, two feet away, you couldn't
tell, right?

SPEAKER 3

And I did see it, but only because
 Arnell had given a little talk
 about it in the department that the
 shoes are in the tile but no this
 way, and a heel that's upside down
 did not even the tile pattern. But
 it doesn't like a matter if you
 don't put shoes on the performer.
 Like, those are the shoes that
 people

SPEAKER 2

will remember, and then the shoes
 are the biggest like, what did

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

your friends say? So, you know the
 actresses.

SPEAKER 2

So I had heard this not from her,
 but from my other friend. I had
 lunch with her the closing week,
 and she was like, because I was
 like, can we talk about the shoes?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Yeah, she does. Oh my God, it was
 your friend in the play in the
 show.

SPEAKER 2

She's, she was a swing, okay? And
 she was in the show, like, in the
 beginning, and then yeah, and she,
 she was like, oh yeah. In
 rehearsal, Rianne, who played
 Imelda, she leaned over to me and
 she goes,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

can you be honest with me,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

these shoes are horrible.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

My shoes, all of my shoes are terrible, right?

SPEAKER 3

Mostly, I just want to make a sitcom where that interaction happens. I just want two Filipina actresses at rehearsal talking about one of them playing Imelda in horrible shooting.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

My horrible shoot. Yeah,

SPEAKER 1

excellent. Wow, so you didn't like the Barong Filipino like that that they went the, like, the flag. It was like, I thought Brown,

SPEAKER 2

yeah, they're cool. I just wasn't sure. They kind of took me out, yeah,

SPEAKER 3

okay, yeah, well, they took me out of de wasn't a revolution that had a uniform. That was exactly the point of the people power. Well, it was a revolution, is it wasn't a war.

SPEAKER 1

They didn't have a uniform, but they had a color. And that color was nowhere on the right.

SPEAKER 3

It was just indicated on the quarry figure a couple times, like two times when she appeared, she was that yellow, bright Corey Aquino yellow.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

And I had to find that out from Instagram.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

I have to find that out from an Instagram account.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Because I was like, there has to be something

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

about this yellow. I just learned that my show, yeah,

SPEAKER 4

we see, like, the dark Martins that were yellow too. Yeah, yeah, which I want really bad, really.

SPEAKER 3

What a strange ass show. Because, like, it opens with a Disney princess number. I'm poor, but I'm pretty. Here's my best friend, slash Yaya, and we're dancing. I'm dancing around in the sheets. She's trying to fold. I mean, I'm like, what the fuck is this? Like, what are we? And then people are clapping. I'm like, even happening we are we're imagining poor Imelda as this, like, pretty, pretty princess. And like, hoping, what, hoping she gets married, like, her entrance

SPEAKER 4

should have been, like, dark and scary, and she, like, walks out with moody shadows.

SPEAKER 3

Okay, let's do the fanfic version.

Because I didn't know. I mean, the grimaldas family of Leyte is a very wealthy family, and now they are fucking like the biggest ballers of the Philippines because of Imelda. But I didn't realize Imelda because they

SPEAKER 1

expropriated a lot of money from that country and or US aid all of them, they put it, yeah, and they pretended it. They found yamashita's Gold, you know what I mean. But it was really like expropriating us money,

SPEAKER 3

like and Imelda gave it all to her family, yeah. But even though I had always I thought the remaldas family was so wealthy, it does turn out. After I saw your Lies Love, I looked it up, Imelda did belong to the poor branch, or whatever, the poorer branch of this rich family. So she she had money until she was eight, and then her mother died, and then she had to go live like whatever Imelda says in a shack. But what we don't know what that means. They did say nipa hut.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Are you kidding? Oh yeah,

SPEAKER 3

but I feel like, obviously this is imelda's villain. Villainous creation story is that she grew up as, like the not center, the non center, marginal of this huge wealth, and then she loses.
Transcribed by <https://otter.ai>

SPEAKER 1

And of course, like that person, that narcissist, having to grow up poor or whatever, is plotting her

revenge on the world from eight years old, and when she's like 17 years old, she's like, that's a handsome politician who is coming closer and closer to my web. I am, we know where we're going with this. Like we're gonna do, you know? I mean, she is, like, I read magazines with fucking JFK Jr, with JFK and Jackie in them. Like, I know, I know what to do next, and she did it, and then she dismantled the rule of law and established a level of corruption in the country that the country's never recovered from. And, like, that's the part I'm like, where is Here Lies Love. Where is the part about the corruption? Where is the part about the rule of laws? No more the Constitution is gone. That every bit of like, law and order has been dismantled in this country. Like, where is no part. And that

SPEAKER 2

was when, because they explained, well, no, they didn't explain. They mentioned that the people were mad at her for some reason, right?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

The people are mad. And they mentioned

SPEAKER 2

some stuff at one point, yeah.

SPEAKER 1

And that's really all we did. That's it. And, like, the thing is that they said, how many people were killed, but it's not in the auditorium, in the projection, but it's not just about how many people die. That makes for an evil government. Like, if you look at how many people this federal administration is killing every day, it's not so many Americans

that they are killing every day.
Like it's not just about that. It's
about what they are doing to the
Constitution, the structure. Yeah,
it's like, how do you how do your
institutions work? How do people
get to go to school or get to make
money, or get to have peaceful
lives, or whatever? Like, can they
just have those things? Or do they
have to constantly be bribing,
like, the next round of officials
and the next round of officials and
like, is that, because the person
at the top is always demanding this
level of bribery, it's like, where
is that story? Which is the only
story? That's the only story of the
Marcus's

SPEAKER 3

it's gone. It's not there. You have
to, you have to read, you have to
read the drama journeys,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

my at least my enemy student, at

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

least he's smart. I do have to feel

SPEAKER 2

like the only the best part of the
entire experience of going to see
that was that, like, just that big
poster

SPEAKER 4

that was like about that was the
context, yeah, that's what

SPEAKER 1

my Eli, that's what my enemy
student, Eli did, and he did good
work.

SPEAKER 2

Yeah, that part was good, yeah?
Because, like, our friend that we
went to see it with her, Sean, I
don't know too well, but she was,
like, pretty excited, because she's
like, I don't really know the
context to this, because my family
literally will not talk about it,
right, right? They're like, we
don't talk about it. We don't want
to, right? We'll not talk about it.
And then she's like, I didn't
really do a lot of my own research,
because, you know, she's like, a
child, right? So, like, you know,
she's like, I kind of want to know.
And then afterwards she's like,
Yeah, I don't

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

really know that much about right,
right?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Exactly, like, I know a couple
names that I'm gonna go look up.

SPEAKER 1

Yeah. It's like, what you said?
It's like, all of a sudden people
got mad at her. Yeah, and the drag
queen said, I don't like you as
much anymore. Like, that's, I'm not
gonna be so fabulous around you. I
mean, that's my protest. Did this
poor drag queen have to give up
drag because, you know, that also
doesn't seem right. Like, why
doesn't? Why doesn't she just start
dressing somebody else? You know
what? Like, what's what's the
lesson here? It's like, oh, now I'm
political. I stopped doing drag.
That's the wrong lesson, right? And
that actually kind of seems like
Filipino though. It's like, oh,
gender normativity is the lesson,
and now we wear all these boring
Catholic school girl uniforms. This
isn't what actually happened, and
it's nothing to valorize.

SPEAKER 5

Now, if you can imagine, and this was a directorial choice changed from Broadway and other in the previous productions, the show used to

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

and with a mega mix of all Imelda songs,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

really, you mean her singing

SPEAKER 5

first, she would sing all the songs used to saying she would sing them again, right?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

It would end in here lies love

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Big Dance, and they're like, partying. Her in the

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

middle, yeah? Just her spinning around, right?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

And a show, right? It's like, Yay, and all done,

SPEAKER 5

like, literally, and the director's like, we're not doing that.

SPEAKER 1

Yeah, yeah. Are you saying there's on the Broadway version. There was the stuff about Ninoy Keenan. There was the part where he died. There

was the boring song that late poor
Lea Salonga had to sing, and as
well as the boring costume, right,
that horrible song, and then then
they had the mega mix with the
dance party. So like a dim
political assassination, people
power revolution, dictators deposed
Mega Man, even more dance party,
even more fun. That is

SPEAKER 2

really, really fucked up. Like, are

SPEAKER 1

you kidding me? That's like, Hitler
in springtime, yeah. Do you know
that

SPEAKER 2

just ended with that? And they're
like, end of show,

SPEAKER 1

yeah, yeah. There is a lot about
here, life's love that I was
thinking about Hitler and
springtime kind of a lot, where I'm
like, what it is, yeah, because is
a joke. Right? In the world of the
producers, they're trying to make a
horribly offensive show that will
fail, and they accidentally make a
show that's usually popular, yeah?
And like, just sitting there, like
not clapping and then, but like
imagining that Megamix thing with
people being like, yeah.

SPEAKER 2

Like, it almost seems purposeful,
like we're gonna do a show that
glorifies Imelda and we're gonna
put her in terrible shoes. Like,
there's no way this is gonna be
good.

SPEAKER 1

It's really weird. It's like, the only theory that works is a conspiracy theory.

SPEAKER 4

Tell me something. Oh, tell me something interesting on that is that Mamma Mia was a big show on Broadway because it became a show in London, in London because it was associated with bridal parties. And so they were really bachelorette parties. Went to Mamma mia,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

yeah, cabaret

SPEAKER 1

theater, yeah, exactly like get drunk, yeah, put on the veil and, like, sing the whole time, yeah.

SPEAKER 4

So with the disco stuff in New York, and here's, Here Lies Love, was this, like, kind of, like, gay, gay disco, party theater thing, or what

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

was there make it, I wasn't very gay, okay.

SPEAKER 1

I mean, like, there wasn't even the drug was no no. So it

SPEAKER 2

wasn't very gay, okay, even though, like, they really missed that. But it's also because the writer didn't, I don't think understands gay, okay? And when Fat Boy Slim was like, we'll write music. I don't care, like whatever, right? I think they were totally checked out of like, whatever. We'll just send

you music for whatever lyrics you
send us. We don't care, yeah, pay
us and we'll send you

SPEAKER 1

some tracks, yeah? But also, I'm
like, I don't want to necessarily
see the story of a drag queen who
used to be a big Imelda fan. It's
like, drag can also be critical.
Drag can be parody and it can be
like, fuck this person.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Like, look at Laura benal. I mean,

SPEAKER 1

there's so many. Like, history is
full of drag. History has just as
many of this kind of drag as fandom
drag. It's like anti fandom drag or
phantom drag, right? And so, like,
why take us on this journey of this
apolitical or fascist drag queen.
It's like those are the only
positions of that drag queen.
Either they know nothing, they're
just ignorant, or they're fascist,
and then they go on this journey,
and then they they like repudiate
their phantom object, and then they
take off their drag. I'm like, what
are we saying? What are we
promoting? What is the character?
What is that character? Yeah, like,
if you think about the MC of
Cabaret, that character who also
just frames the story, or whatever,
does kind of go on a journey, and
it's not this journey, though, you
can kind of sketch out a political
journey that isn't whatever that
was so odd, so strange, like any of
these choices, I'm just like, who
was, who was watching The store
when this choice was made, who was
saying, this is okay, yeah, was it
Alex's mother?

SPEAKER 2

Was she was just trying to, I think
she was trying to, like, salvage
whatever she could. I think she was
like, well, this

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

show is gonna happen without with
her, yeah,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

David Byrne and fat by slam.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

So I'll try. I'll try my artist

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

so like, put some Filipino mess.

SPEAKER 1

Well, you know what? I have some
good news for everyone at this
table, which is that we had nothing
to do with this show, and we should
be really proud of that. Yes, this
is the kind of show where, at the
end of it, you should just be glad
nobody wrote you in in any way.

SPEAKER 5

Well, when, I mean, when I had
lunch with my friend. I did tell
her, because, you know, I
auditioned for the show. Oh yeah, I
remember that.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

And I said, they say they protected
you by not

SPEAKER 5

putting you. And I said, I was
like, I was like, really, I'm
really proud of you.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

All. You all so talented.

SPEAKER 3

But not once did I ever during the
show think, God, I wish I was up.
Can you

SPEAKER 1

imagine how you do those stupid
dances? I'm part of a MEL just
entourage, like, oh my god,

SPEAKER 2

that dance with the stupid little
face, like papers

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

the masks just bad.

SPEAKER 2

Oh, that also is a number that
looks good from the front, but
like, they brought the door out. So
like, where we were sitting,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

we could see them lined up. They
brought the

SPEAKER 2

door out past us, and then we saw
them all line up behind the doors,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

like, Oh no, kidding me. Are you
kidding?

SPEAKER 2

And there's a whole stage that
they're just not using, yeah, not
to use it and kind of do like
theater in the round, yeah, but
never stage it for the round at
all.

SPEAKER 5

The only thing that kind of helped for us, it was good for us, was whenever they were up in the those little platforms, yeah, yeah, oh, yeah, yeah,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

right, that was at least maybe

SPEAKER 2

we couldn't even read the projection, because it was a bump.

SPEAKER 5

It curved towards us so like I could read half of the foot sentences,

SPEAKER 4

Oh, no. And I was wondering, because it wasn't symmetrical. So I was like, there was some construction of the real stage with this bow proscenium, right?

SPEAKER 1

Because Arnell, this is so terrible. I'm working, I'm about to be chair of a bad Filipino, American scenic designer, like, what? But because, because arnell's whole conception for this show was those lunchtime performances on Filipino TV variety shows like these, Filipino variety shows, give these lunch have these lunchtime things where it's just like an hour of like, straight singing and dancing. It's like, boom, boom, boom, boom, you know, like, just a bunch of random ass shit. And so that was what he was thinking of for the design, right? It's like, have you been in Philippines? It's like, do you know, like, Filipinos don't even know a gray or beige are

SPEAKER 2

like, it looked like primer. It was gonna get painted. It looked like Prime Minister.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Right? Yeah, it did look like primer.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

No, if it was bright, I would

SPEAKER 1

be like, oh, and Imelda. And Imelda shoes looked like rehearsal shoes. Like, well, these aren't the real shoes, but just to save your feet the first time, in these bad pumps for me, in the fat Yeah,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

in that chunky heel, yeah,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

she doesn't have money yet. Okay, she's

SPEAKER 1

right, right, yeah, artistic choice, like the best. She kept coming out in that they were her wedding shoes. I mean, barkles got married in shoes like that. I will eat those because she did it, yeah? Like she just didn't, and we have pictures. I mean, also it's like they failed to understand her as a human, like she should have

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

been like a monster with, like, light up shoes, yeah?

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Similar problem with, oh, it's

SPEAKER 5

really good. Oh, I don't know
they're historical. It's a real
event, historical

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

people. And in

SPEAKER 5

Parade they, like, when they would
enter, they projected a

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

picture of them. We talked about
this,

SPEAKER 5

oh, oh yeah, yeah, the actual
person. And then the actors cost
him with nothing, like nothing, and
like, they projected a picture of
Mel's wedding, yeah, and it looked
nothing like what she was wearing,
right? Or stage your own, right?
Just take it. Just take the
picture.

SPEAKER 2

Yeah? Like, in Parade, like someone
comes out with like, very distinct
facial hair, yeah? And then
someone's not just, like, clean
shaven, or just, like a, like, a
beard, right? It was like, This
person had like, mutton shot.
You're like, don't show us that,
right? We don't. And then the worst
thing about that, though, was they
had all the real people pictures of
all the white people. So when the
black characters came out, they
just projected black man, and then
they not actual character.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Like, just, here's any black

SPEAKER 1

man, wow. They just showed a random black man, yes. So what they should have done, yeah, was take cast photos. They should have just taken the photos if they wanted to say who the characters were, or

SPEAKER 2

just like the script says, Every time someone comes up, they say their name, like the script is fine. It's not like an elusive

SPEAKER 1

script that's a really weird choice. And a lot of the Here lie swamp choices were really, really weird choices. And now I feel like, after this conversation, I can never say anything about that show again. Now it's the fucking I actually think this production gave this musical life, like, now this thing will be reproduced. Yeah, that's why, because Mark Taper center, center theater group made money

SPEAKER 3

off of this place. They said the highest grossing really,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

show of all time. No, really.

SPEAKER 5

So theater's gonna be like, yes, they saw the Broadway production, and they said, We can't do that. We can't produce that huge.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

It closed after three months.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

But regionally, they're like, Oh,

SPEAKER 1

we can make money. It's this
production that will and so forever
Filipino actors are gonna have
we're

SPEAKER 2

gonna have to do that coffee shop.
So it's like, you either have to
play in this show about a dictator,
or you can go and play a Vietnamese
prostitute.

SPEAKER 5

Yeah? I mean, my show exists, but
that's it, right? My song
selection, musical is also feels
hard to produce, yeah,

SPEAKER 1

well, we're gonna make the Filipino
beep The other option, yeah, it'll
be the Our Town. Yeah, it'll be the
Our Town option, yeah, this little
Filipino American theater, there's
the West Side Story option, that's
Here Lies Love, yeah? Philippine
deep will be the R town option,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

sorry, I'm so slow with these. Food
is definitely more involved, yeah,
I'm

SPEAKER 6

so glad I didn't get to the
killers. I mean, oh yeah, one of my
favorite dishes. But that

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

was great. My God, that looks
amazing. Yeah, this,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

this was amazing.

SPEAKER 1

I mean, now you know, they're in my performing diversity class, which was about diversity and all the things, including theater, one of my Latina students, did a little presentation on like, West Side Story, and she used our labs, tagging methodology, and she was like, you know, at the end she she gave it a score. I don't remember if it was like, good or bad. She gave she wrote the blur. And the whole thing was very confused, because it was like, there were lots of positive and lots of negatives and everything just kind of seemed to average out. And at the end, I was like, Well, what do you really think of West Side Story, though? I mean, do you hate it? Is it just boring? Is it mediocre? Like, from all everything you did with this, I can't even really tell where you landed. And she was like, that's because I hate it. And so does everybody, like all Latinos hate it, and we hope it gets produced every season everywhere, and we audition every time, all of us, and we go out really hard for the audition, and we don't care when a West Side Story opens. We're like, great. Now we're all going to audition for that. And I'm like, that's that's sad, but now we have ours.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

We're getting closer to equality.

SPEAKER 1

Welcome to neoliberal America. Every minority gets a shitty, shitty musical that makes a lot of money that every actor from that group wants to audition for every time. But, like,

SPEAKER 2

the thing is, though, is that, I mean, some people do love the stone, some people like but, like, with Miss Saigon is the same thing where it's like, yeah, I know a lot of people that are like, I would love to do something else, anything guys commit suicide for a white man. Yeah, anything else but that? Yeah, I know. And that means so that got every Filipino woman their

SPEAKER 1

equity card I know, which I sometimes wonder about Vietnamese American actors, and what they think about Miss Saigon being like a showcase for Filipino Americans. But one time I was, I was in England, you know, I did my one semester abroad in England, and it was so horrible, and there were no Filipino people, anywhere the food, except for South Asian food, is tragic. And I said, I am going to go see some Filipino people right now. And I took the train to London and bought a ticket to masaga. I was like, I'm just going to be in the company of Filipino people. And John, John was the engineer, wow, production. So that was great. But like, it was weird, because you're like, this actually happened in the Philippines too. Like, it could just be about Philippines, but instead it's about Vietnamese women. But that's okay, I guess. Is it okay? I'm not sure, but yeah, I see white men

SPEAKER 2

because it's yeah, of course, that's where it all comes back to, yeah.

SPEAKER 1

All right, yeah. I mean, all of

these shows we're talking about are strange. They're very odd, and it's odd how much money they make, and people love them, and like, she kills herself, and then was Saigon, and people like, I'm crying, I'm like, What is even, what are you doing? Should be angry. You know, the whole audience all the time in these shows, how beautiful. I told

SPEAKER 2

you about the play. Not another truth, not this is not a this is,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

this is not

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

a truth about Kim from Miss Saigon.

SPEAKER 1

Oh, yeah, yeah, that sounded amazing. Oh my gosh, yeah.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Tell Benjamin three historically Asian characters.

SPEAKER 2

What's the Madam Butterfly character name? Oh, the

SPEAKER 1

one in m butterfly is named. It's named song. But I don't know if I don't think that's the name in, I think in Puccini, she's just butterfly, oh, but in, but in m butterfly, she is Song lilling, I think, Well, whoever.

SPEAKER 2

I can't remember that name, but the Madame Butterfly, Puccini character. Then there's Kim, and

then there's so it's first, just
the two of them in, like, the

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

afterlife, well, first, and just
one of them.

SPEAKER 2

Oh yeah, first. And they just have
to keep reliving their story over
and over, of like, having a baby
and then killing and they're like,
living their life, like, Hold on, I
have to have a baby now and then,
like, oh, not to kill myself. And
then they discover and then Kim
comes along and is doing the same
thing. And then they bring in the
woman that was, like, made tabloids
for like, they said that she was,
like, thought the Fargo story was
real, and

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

tried to pay search that and passed
away.

SPEAKER 2

Like, searching for the, oh, the
Fargo

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

treasure, treasure, oh, which

SPEAKER 2

was a true story. She thought that
it says this is a true story. So
she believed it. And like, wow. And
like, came from Japan, I think, Oh,
wow. And like, and yeah, and died.
But there was, like,

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

a, there's a real story about it.
Yeah, it,

SPEAKER 2

yeah, but there's like, the real,
like, fake story that is, like, she
was just this delusional woman
that, like, which is not the
correct story, but it's all these
people, like, trying to, like,
maybe deal with their own story as
they're having to relive the story
told about them over and over. So
the you

SPEAKER 5

learn, you learn later that the
reason why we keep seeing it over
and over again is that it's a
metaphor for how many times that
play gets produced. So every time
there we see their character die,
like, oh, another production is
happening. Oh, another production
is happening. And it gets to this
thing where some they're like, We
need to stop this. Yeah. Like, we
we can tell other stories. We can
tell our own story. But every time
they do, every time they do, they
get it gets reset and, yeah, relive
it over and over again. So it's
about like trying to reclaim your
story and what possibly that looks
like, yeah, and in this version, it
like it ends up like destroying the
book that they're attracted, yeah,
and they the in the stage
directions. It's like, the page is
rip. Every time they go off script,
a rip, a rip in the script happens
until at the end where they they
just fully rip up the script. Never
performs again. And they're like,
What do we do? And they're like, I
guess we write our own story. So it
ends with them writing their own
Okay,

SPEAKER 2

where it's so simple and kind of
cheesy, but like, yeah, done in
such a beautiful way that we were
like, I only want

SPEAKER 5

to cry. I like, first saw a reading
of it in Chicago. Little Black Box
reading, nice, no staging, yeah,
and the cheers that were that
erupted from the audience, like,
when they, like, ripped that book
open, they told that white man to
get out of there. Yeah, it was
like, amazing

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Theater Company and produced that.

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

But I feel like they would, it
would be such a good home for

SPEAKER 2

Philippines, because a I feel like
they they put the work in, and so
the shows always look beautiful,
yeah, and they would love that
story, yeah, yeah.

SPEAKER 1

Well, let's see. I have my meeting.
Oh, just talked to you on

UNKNOWN SPEAKER

Philippine de, okay, I'm gonna
stop. Transcribed by
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